Supporters of strongmen often don’t see this process as anti-democratic. They are genuinely baffled when told that electoral victory doesn’t grant them unlimited power. Instead, they see any check on the power of an elected government as undemocratic. However, democracy doesn’t mean majority rule; rather, it means freedom and equality for all. Democracy is a system that guarantees everyone certain liberties, which even the majority cannot take away.

Nobody disputes that in a democracy the representatives of the majority are entitled to form the government and to advance their preferred policies in myriad fields. If the majority wants war, the country goes to war. If the majority wants peace, the country makes peace. If the majority wants to raise taxes, taxes are raised. If the majority wants to lower taxes, taxes are lowered. Major decisions about foreign affairs, defence, education, taxation and numerous other policies are all in the hands of the majority.

But in a democracy, there are two baskets of rights that are protected from the majority’s grasp. One contains human rights. Even if 99 per cent of the population wants to exterminate the remaining 1 per cent, in a democracy this is forbidden, because it violates the most basic human right – the right to life. The basket of human rights contains many additional rights, such as the right to work, the right to privacy, freedom of movement and freedom of religion. These rights enshrine the decentralised nature of democracy, making sure that as long as people don’t harm anyone, they can live their lives as they see fit.

The second crucial basket of rights contains civil rights. These are the basic rules of the democratic game, which enshrine its self-correcting mechanisms. An obvious example is the right to vote. If the majority were permitted to disenfranchise the minority, then democracy would be over after a single election. Other civil rights include freedom of the press, academic freedom and freedom of assembly, which enable independent media outlets, universities and opposition movements to challenge the government. These are the key rights that strongmen seek to violate. While sometimes it is necessary to make changes to a country’s self-correcting mechanisms – for example, by expanding the franchise, regulating the media or reforming the judicial system – such changes should be made only on the basis of a broad consensus including both majority and minority groups. If a small majority could unilaterally change civil rights, it could easily rig elections and get rid of all other checks on its power.